

Research Statement

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I am an applied economist and a Ph.D. candidate in Agricultural and Applied Economics at the University of Wisconsin–Madison. My fields are political economy, economic history, development and public economics, with a second line of work in industrial organization. My research examines how asymmetric information shapes the taxation of farms and the adoption of new technology: in agriculture the farmer knows more about the harvest and its quality than the state that taxes the farm or the buyer who pays for the crop. I study these problems mostly under autocracy, where the central government collects its taxes and allocates technology through local officials who know more than it does and whose interests differ from its own, a principal–agent problem inside the state.

Under autocracy these officials answer only upward, for a target; no free press, court or vote watches them from below, and the people they act on have little room to refuse. That is what makes the practice dangerous: the officials' knowledge serves the target, and the cost falls on the people, in extreme cases in lives. The danger is present, not past: autocracies now outnumber democracies.

Job Market Paper

What the practice costs is the question of my job market paper, **“Power Without Information: The Human Cost of Uniform Land Taxation in Subsistence Agriculture.”** I answer it on the extreme case, the Soviet state's taxation of collective farms in the 1930s, where the state could punish without limit and still could not see the harvest. On the annual accounts of 272 collective farms, digitized from the state's own survey, I show that the tax cost one member in twenty-eight, in excess deaths and expulsions, and that most of this cost, 63 per cent, came not from the information constraint but from the incentive constraint, the discretion of its own officials.

The mechanism operates through two things the state could not do: see the harvest, and bend the officials who collected the tax to its own will. Before 1933 the state took a share of each farm's assessed harvest, so the harvest estimate mattered, and the farm understated it while the assessor overstated it. In January 1933 the state moved its claim to the hectare, which it could count: a fixed rent in grain per hectare sown, the same for every farm of a district. This statutory rent no longer depended on any harvest estimate, but it could no longer follow the harvest either, and it left a third of the farms below subsistence. Collection was delegated to district officials who answered under criminal liability for a district target. With a better sense of the district's harvest than the centre, they took about a third more than the statutory rent, more in districts with better harvests, though the centre had forbidden it, and this discretion left two thirds of the farms below subsistence. The centre repaired part of what its officials had taken, but only the part it could verify: it could inspect a farm's seed against its registered area, not the food divided among the members, so in the spring it lent seed and little food. The next sowing was restored; over the year that followed the harvest, the farms left with less food lost more members. Better information would have removed the smaller part of the cost; the larger part was the officials' response to the centre's own threat.

Taxation and Famine

In **“Taxing What the State Could See: The Design of Soviet Grain Procurement and the Famine of 1933,”** I turn to the system the fixed rent replaced and to what its local officials actually took from the harvest of 1932, and ask whether that extraction was enough to produce the famine. On the state's regional surveys of collective farms, I show that in most regions the harvest was enough to feed the farms' members, but that after the extraction most of their farms fell below subsistence, and that the depth of the shortfall predicts the rise in mortality between regions. Ukraine, where the famine struck hardest, lost no

more to the extraction than the other grain-producing regions; but within regions, districts with more Ukrainians had higher mortality. One reading of that difference, which regional data cannot test, is that local officials went further there than the tax required, in the searches, seizures and violence of the local campaigns that the archives describe and no survey records.

Technology Adoption

The other main agricultural policy of the 1930s, mechanization, ran through a design like the tax's: an agency appointed from the centre, working to a plan, held the tractors and allocated their work to the collective farms. In **"Victory over Peasantry: Extractive Institutions and the Big Push,"** with Paul Castañeda Dower and Vladimir Gimpelson, we ask whether a Big Push, the coordinated adoption of a technology with increasing returns, can deliver growth under extractive institutions. On farm-level audit data we find that mechanization raised output and labour productivity only a little, and mainly by extending the sown area. The agency's services were misallocated, scale brought no economies, and the farm's share of its output did not rise, so the members of mechanized farms stayed at or below subsistence: as with the tax, the state's agent delivered its plan, and the farms gained little. In a market, by contrast, the adopter invests by choice, and its return can depend on the buyer it sells to; that possibility is what my second line of work studies. In **"Technology, Contracts, and Coordination: Modernizing Agricultural Supply Chains in Wisconsin Potatoes,"** I ask whether a supplier's sunk investment in quality pays when quality is costly to monitor and a retailer can hold up the return. A wholesaler that installed a quality-sorting, cost-saving technology and then signed long-term contracts with a retail chain lowered its marginal cost by a tenth of the price, and the contracts added to its margin.

Ongoing Work and Future Plans

My ongoing research turns to the other instrument of the autocratic state, repression. In the early 1930s the centre set for each region the number of households to be removed as kulaks and left the choice of whom to the district: a similar delegation problem. I have assembled a registry of the persons dispossessed or disenfranchised in the Ural region from a database built on the district archives, which covers rural repression more completely than the widely used Memorial database, and matched it to the 1928 settlement census; where the database leaves a part of the region uncovered, I am reading the archives myself. Joined to the farm accounts, the registry will show who was removed and what their removal did to the farms; my aim is to bring the state's capacity to repress into the same account as its capacity to extract. Alongside it I am extending the coverage of the district panel behind these papers, which follows the state's agricultural policy across the Urals year by year. Over the coming years I plan to carry this research further along the same line: to measure what autocratic rule cost on ever more complete records from the archives, at the level of the district, the settlement and the farm, so that the state's instruments of extraction, allocation and repression can be studied together.

I aim to publish in general-interest journals and in the field journals of economic history, development, political economy and public economics. The datasets behind this work, the farm panel, the district panel and the registry, will be released with the papers, so that others can check what I claim and ask what I have not. The purpose of my research is to shed light on the atrocities of the autocratic state and to educate, with robust measurement rather than assertion, about what autocratic practices cost, in extreme cases in human lives.